

soft, furlike
plumage



△ LITTLE SPOTTED KIWI

The little spotted kiwi (*A. owenii*) often lays two eggs, three weeks apart, on a bed of moss. Each egg is a quarter of the female's weight.

North Island brown kiwi

Apteryx mantelli

Nothing else looks remotely like a kiwi, but they share their origins with other flightless birds and are most closely related to emus and cassowaries. Kiwis prefer rainforest, but habitat loss has forced them into scrub and pine plantations, from coasts to alpine regions. They need high humidity, well-drained soil for digging nesting burrows and daytime dens, and moist leaf litter in which to find food such as worms and grubs at night. They detect prey by sound, smell, and touch, leaving a trail of holes where they have probed with their bill.

Extraordinary eggs

Kiwis form life-long pairs in fixed territories, digging burrows months or years before using them for nesting, so new growth disguises the entrance.

Females are bigger than males, and produce eggs four times as large as might be expected for the bird's size. The North Island brown kiwi's egg may be 20 percent of the body weight, its yolk an exceptional 60 percent of the egg's volume. The egg takes a month to develop, and in this time the grossly distended female stops feeding. Incubation is by the male, using a temporary brood patch on his belly to keep the egg warm, and may last 90 days.

large feet with
fleshy pads and
long, sharp claws

long, slender bill

△ NATIONAL ICON

New Zealand's national bird, the kiwi's big round body, small head, and long, slim bill make it instantly recognizable around the world.

- ↔ 20–26 in (51–66 cm)
- ⚖ 6–8 lb (2.7–3.6 kg)
- ⊗ Endangered
- 🐛 Insects, worms, millipedes
- 🏠 



N. New Zealand